



Classic Worldtimer Manufacture: Blue gradient dial with embossed continents, 72-hour power reserve and an interchangeable alligator strap; Classic Worldtimer Manufacture: Light blue dial with the bezel set with 70 diamonds, limited to 88 pieces

"EVEN NEGATIVE COMMENTS MATTER BECAUSE THEY TELL YOU WHERE TO IMPROVE."

— **Niels Eggerding,** CEO, Frederique Constant

our more classical pieces rather than competing with them.

This year, you've gone deeper into mechanical watchmaking with the Worldtimer, but also more design-forward with the Manchette. Is this dual direction intentional going forward?

Yes, absolutely. A few years ago, we made a conscious decision to focus on two things. The first, was reaching a younger audience, speaking more directly to Gen Z and millennials through both communication and product. The challenge, of course, is that the product still needs to appeal to our existing audience at the same time. That balance is not easy, but I think we've managed it.

The second was becoming more relevant to collectors. That's driven collaborations with people like Peter Speake-Marin, seconde/seconde/, and Watch Angels, as well as unique and limited pieces, and more technically ambitious watches. Collectors are extremely important; they influence broader buying behaviour far beyond their own purchases. We are still a mass brand, but if you don't connect with collectors, you don't build long-term desirability. Over the last five years, we've clearly gained traction in that space.

There's a clear push towards more wearable proportions and longer power reserves. Do you think collectors today are prioritising practicality over pure complication?

Collectors want a mix. They're looking for uniqueness and a sense of scarcity, a strong design identity, and mechanical credibility. But they also expect something slightly outside the brand's traditional DNA—something unexpected. So it's not really a question of practicality versus complication. It's about offering something distinctive that still feels relevant. The two aren't mutually exclusive.

Frederique Constant has been a pioneer in bringing in-house movements to accessible price points. Do you feel that message is fully understood by today's consumer, or does a gap still exist?

I'll be honest, in our price segment, most consumers don't really care. We like to believe they do, but the reality is different. For a typical buyer, design comes first, price comes second, and technical details come much later. If someone is buying a €1,200 (₹1.32 lakh) automatic watch, they are not making that decision based on whether the power reserve is 38 or 72 hours. For collectors, it's a different story; they understand and value it. But for the majority, it's an emotional and visual purchase.

We still offer in-house movements because it's part of our philosophy— delivering strong value for the price. But it doesn't necessarily drive the purchase decision for most people. That kind of honesty matters if you want to build a brand that actually connects with the people buying it.

By **Rizwan Bachav**